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Strategies of status manipulation in the Wolof greeting

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Joking relationship (kall) and the joking greeting • Status strategies: self-lowering and self-elevating

Lat Dior saddled up, accompanied by the infants, all of whom he used to go around with, and the guns [i.e., his entire court]. It was at this very hour that they came suddenly to Kir Matar [Songo's town]. The royal drums arrived in the town square. They formed a barricade with the horses. They sent a messenger; they said, 'When you go, tell Songo Aminata it is Lat Dior who calls him to the town square. It is he who greets him.'

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Songo Aminata came out. He wrapped around himself two cloths; he loaded his shoulders with two guns. He went out of the house of the Ndiayes; he came to the town square. He just forded [crossed through] the people [who were like a river]; everyone who was there was laughing, swearing 'Today Lat Dior will kill.' They swore, 'These things which he [Songo Aminata] does in the country will only be complete when Lat Dior kills him. This man, he did not follow after Lat Dior and those whom he causes to accompany him.' And Songo Aminata was not startled. He arrived just crossing through the battlefield. They made way for him that he might pass through the middle of the assembly, just to arrive.

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He [Songo Aminata] said, 'My hand, Lat Dior - yes, Diop?' He [Lat Dior] said to him, 'Yes, Ndiaye?' Everyone there was very quiet. Kayor and Baol, the region of the town was chock full. Everyone thus stared at them. Their two foreheads touched; they were speechless - until it was a very long time. Songo Aminata said to him, 'Lat Dior, why did you come here?' He said to him, 'I have spent two months here, between when I came and now.' They were silent. He said to him, 'Songo Aminata, why is it that I had sent to you an envoy who came from Kayor to here, and you did not come to answer me?' He said to him, 'When you came to Baiti Mbaye, heading toward me, Kîr Matar and Baiti Mbaye are one. It is I that you came to. The stranger, it is he who comes to greet the town.' He was silent.¹⁰

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The strategy applied by Songo Aminata can also be stated formally: see T-rule 6 in the grammar.

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Joking relationship (kall) and the joking greeting

There are certain special cases of greeting which show an alteration both in the form of the greeting and in the social innuendo which the greeting conveys. These cases depend on the particular surnames which are stated by both parties in the naming section of the greeting. Certain pairs of surnames, and the kin groups which bear them, stand in a special relationship to each other, called *kall* 'joking relationship.' The families Diop and Ndiaye, for example, are in joking relationship because, supposedly, 'the Diops are the mothers of the Ndiayes.' In fact the founding ancestor of the village, a man whose surname was Ndiaye, was born of a mother whose surname was Diop. The relationship between the two families echoes the relationship between a mother and her grown son, a relationship which is ■181 ambiguous as to precedence and authority. Not all *kall* pairs have a kinship justification - some pairs are 'just friends.' But Wolof informants said that what is 'really' going on in the exchange of insults in a joking relationship is that each person is claiming, *Maa ko moom*, 'It is I who own him'; or 'I am the master and the other is my slave.' This claim must be implicit in the insults, because it is not often actually uttered in the course of the joking repartee.

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10. Ultimately the local chief, Songo Aminata, manages to avoid a battle by convincing Lat Dior that the king was himself at fault for abandoning Kayor - and those who took advantage of the king's absence should not be blamed for doing so. The historical narrative from which this **text** is drawn was told to me by M. Malik Mbengue.

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